

L-49: INDIAN SOCIETY — Comprehensive Notes

Sarrthi IAS | Anthropology Foundation | Nataraj Sir | Paper 1 (Units 3.2, 3.3, 5.3) | Team Avengers

L-49 TOPIC MAP & INTER-LINKAGES

3.2 Jajmani System ↔ 3.2 Tribe-Caste Continuum ↔ 5.3b Great & Little Tradition ↔ 5.3b Universalisation & Parochialisation
↔ 3.3 Sacred Complex ↔ 3.3 NMS Complex

Jajmani links castes in village → Tribe-Caste shows mobility between categories → GT/LT explains cultural layers → U&P shows movement between layers → Sacred Complex is GT/LT integration at pilgrim sites → NMS is tribal worldview linking ecology + spirit

3.2 JAJMANI SYSTEM

Origin & Definition

Aspect	Detail
First reported by	William H. Wiser — <i>The Hindu Jajmani System</i> (1936)
Field site	Karimpur village, Uttar Pradesh
Regional equivalents	<i>Yajamani</i> (Tamil Nadu), <i>Jenmi</i> (Kerala)
Nature	Agriculture-based system of production & distribution of goods and services through hereditary ties

Oscar Lewis (1958): "Under this system each caste group within a village is expected to give certain standardized services to the families of other castes." — Based on Wiser's work; studied **Rampur village, UP**.

Key Stakeholders

Term	Meaning	Status
Jajman	Higher caste person who <i>receives</i> services	Called <i>Rajah</i> (King)
Kamin	Lower caste person who <i>performs</i> services (<i>kam karne wala</i>)	Called <i>subjects</i>

Wiser first drew attention to the system but did not know it was **universal** in Indian villages.

Oscar Lewis — Rampur Village Study (Jats & Service Castes)

Caste	Service to Jats (landowners)
Kumhaar (Potter)	Supplies earthen vessels
Lohar (Blacksmith)	Supplies agricultural tools
Kachhi (Carpenter)	Supplies & repairs wooden tools
Nai (Barber)	Shaving and haircutting

- Servicing castes (artisans, barbers, washermen) linked with **land-owning dominant castes**
- Barber dresses hair; carpenter meets woodwork needs; ironsmith makes agricultural implements
- A system of **social, economic & cultural ties** between different caste groups

6 Characteristics of Jajmani System

#	Feature	Details
1	Permanent relationships	Kamin cannot leave Jajman; Jajman cannot replace Kamin. Lifelong fixed relations; rural economy remains stable.
2	Hereditary	Rights divided like property on family separation (N.S. Reddy). Pass to son; if no male heir, to son-in-law.
3	Goods against services	Payment in cash/kind (not employer-employee). Carpenter (Khati) : 1 mound grain/year + 2-3 seers at harvest. Sweeper (Chuhra) : 2 meals/day + as much grain as he could carry at harvest + food at marriages.
4	Social (not just economic)	Humanitarian relation. Jajman takes full responsibility for Kamin's welfare; Kamin serves with devotion & dedication.
5	Peace & contentment	W.H. Wiser : Kamins feel security (not worried about employment); Jajmans assured of services.
6	Ritual dimension	Kamins perform ritual/ceremonial duties at birth, marriage, death of Jajman's family.

Ritual Example: Thakur Family (Lucknow, UP)

 **Oscar Lewis (1958)** gave this example — a Thakur (Rajput) family served by **10 castes** for life-cycle rites. All who help receive gifts of food, money, clothes depending on custom, Jajman's affluence, and recipient's requests:

Caste	Ritual Role
Brahmin	Presides over <i>nama-sanskarana</i> (naming ceremony)
Sunar (Goldsmith)	Provides gold ornaments for newborn
Dhobi (Washerman)	Washes dirty clothes
Nai (Barber)	Carries messages
Khati (Carpenter)	Provides wooden stool (<i>patta</i>) for ceremony
Lohar (Blacksmith)	Provides <i>kara</i> (bracelet)
Kumhar (Potter)	Provides <i>kulhar</i> (jugs) for drinking water
Pasi	Provides <i>patal</i> (leaf plates)
Bhangi (Scavenger)	Cleans place after feast

Disadvantages of the Jajmani System

Disadvantage	Detail
1. Instrument of exploitation & discrimination	 Oscar Lewis — in Rampur study: what was once based on personal relationships has now become an instrument of exploitation of Kamins by Jajmans.
2. Restricts social mobility	Hereditary nature = no possibility of changing occupation. System has checked social mobility of lower castes.
3. Supported by caste system	 Oscar Lewis — suffers from all evils of caste system. Conditions of Kamins are miserable; upper castes subject them to great harassment and trouble .

Different Scholarly Perspectives

Scholar (Year)	Focus	Key Argument
 Pauline Kolenda (1963)	Occupational division of labour in Indian agricultural village	She looks at it as a system of distribution — higher-caste Jajmans provided services/products by lower castes.
 Berremen (1953)	Social dynamics	"It is not easy for an agriculturist to remove a family attached to his household and secure the services of another."
 Harold Gould (1972)	Internal functioning	Jajmani relations operate at family level — a Rajput family has ties with one family each from Brahmin, barber, carpenter, etc. A service caste family offers services to specific Jajman families.

Functions of the Jajmani System

- Regulates **division of labour & economic interdependence** of castes
- Maintains the Indian village as a **self-sufficient unit**
- Distributes agricultural produce in exchange for menial & craft services
- Maintains **prestige of higher castes** — Kamins are expected to render services; paid in cash/kind at fixed intervals
- Clients of Kamins may be from same or different villages

Factors of Change (4 Trends)

 **Yogendra Singh** identified 4 major trends of change:

#	Trend	Impact on Jajmani
1	Subsistence → Surplus economy	Shift in economic power from landowners to non-agricultural groups; alters traditional patronage & dependence
2	Introduction of modern technology	New economic opportunities; changes traditional division of labour & patron-client relationships
3	Abolition of intermediaries (Zamindars)	Alters traditional power structure; emergence of new forms of economic & political power
4	Emergence of associations/institutions with urban/national linkages	New avenues for social & economic mobility; fragmentation of traditional relationships; rise of new power centres

Decline of Jajmani System (Post-Independence)

Cause	Mechanism
1. Role of State	Planned development: state provided credit facilities, fertilizers, irrigation, HYV seeds — broke Jajman's monopoly as sole provider to Kamins
2. Technical innovations & industrialization	Machine-made goods flooded rural areas — artisan castes literally made to compete with machines : - Safety razors → self-shaving popular → barbers decline - Steel utensils → potters decline - Bore wells & hand pumps → kahaars (water carriers) decline
3. Political mobilization of Dalits & backward classes	Constitution committed to upliftment & empowerment. New sense of identity among Dalits & OBCs . Democratic assertion = serious blow to exploitative system based on monopolistic rights of landed higher castes.

Memory Aid — Jajmani Decline (STP): State intervention | Technology flooding rural markets | Political mobilization of backward classes

ANTHROPOLOGICAL SIGNIFICANCE & CONTEMPORARY RELEVANCE

- Understanding rural social structure:** Jajmani system explains how Indian villages functioned as self-sufficient economic units before market economy — central to understanding India's transition from feudalism to capitalism.
- Caste-class nexus:** Shows how caste hierarchy was economically reinforced — relevant to understanding why caste persists despite modernization (Andre Beteille's work on inequality).
- Labour relations lens:** Provides anthropological baseline for comparing pre-capitalist labour relations with modern gig economy, contract labour, and informal sector — both involve patron-dependency but differ in mobility.
- Contemporary remnants:** Ritual Jajmani persists at marriages/funerals in rural UP, Bihar, Rajasthan (barbers carry messages, Brahmins officiate, potters supply ritual items). Economic Jajmani has nearly died.
- MGNREGA parallel:** State has replaced Jajman as provider of employment security — validates the decline thesis. Rural distress migration shows what happens when both Jajmani AND state fail.
- Critique of functionalism:** Wiser's harmonious view (peace & contentment) vs Lewis's exploitation critique mirrors the broader functionalism vs conflict theory debate in anthropology.

3.2 TRIBE-CASTE CONTINUUM

Origin of Concept

Aspect	Detail
Concept coined by	 R. Redfield in <i>The Folk Culture of Yucatan</i>
Original model	' Folk-Urban Continuum ' — cultural shift from rural to urban is a gradual process, illustrating a spectrum of changes in lifestyle, values, and socio-economic structures
Applied to India by	Bailey & Surajit Sinha — rechristened as ' Tribe-Caste Continuum '
What it shows	Process of social mobility taking place among Indian villages and tribal communities

Continuum: A gradual progression or range of something without any clear boundaries or sudden changes.

TRIBE ←————→ CASTE
Totally Isolated → Partially Isolated → In Cultural Contact → Totally Assimilated
 (Onge, Sentinelese) (Chenchu) (Gonds)
 (Meeraasi / Bhumiij)

4 Scholars' Attempts to Distinguish Tribe & Caste

1. **J.H. Hutton's Classification**

- Distinction primarily in terms of **religious beliefs and practices**
- If a group has **animist beliefs** → classified as tribe
- Otherwise → classified into caste
- Economic, political, ecological factors = **secondary importance**

2. Andre Beteille's Classification (3 criteria)

Criterion	Tribe	Caste
1. Relative Geographic Isolation	Geographically isolated, in inaccessible areas; a world within itself , few external social ties	By its nature, part of a larger whole , linked by multifarious ties with other castes
2. Dialect	Speak dialects that differ markedly from major Indian languages	Speak regional/major languages
3. Religion	A " loose criterion " — "what we encounter is a continuum without sharp breaks; where we draw the line between 'tribal' and 'non-tribal' remains arbitrary"	

3. F.G. Bailey — Structural Distinction

- Took all points raised by sociologists into account; presented scheme to discriminate in **structural terms**
- Suggests: don't view 'tribe' and 'caste' **disjunctively** — view them in terms of continuum
- Caste society = organic and hierarchical**
- Tribal society = segmentary and egalitarian**
- Made distinction in relation to **politico-economic system** (not totality of behaviour)
- Aware both are transforming: "**both caste and tribe are being merged into a different system which is neither one nor the other**"
- Limitation:** As caste and tribe cease to fit classical definitions, practical value of Bailey's scheme is limited

4. Surajit Sinha — Fieldwork in Bastar

- Disciple of Redfield; studied Tribe-Caste continuum through fieldwork **among tribes of Bastar**
- Lower castes in India share with tribes: **emphasis on equality** in social behaviour
- Give considerable **freedom for women** in cultural activities
- Supernatural beliefs** of lower castes have similarities with tribal beliefs

Tribes & Hinduisation

Ghurye (1943): Called tribal populations "an **imperfectly integrated segment of the Hindus**" — '**backward Hindus**'. Presence of Khasa & Bhils in Ramayana/Mahabharata shows tribes maintained cultural contacts with Hindu society despite general isolation.

Scholar	Work	Key Contribution
 N.K. Bose	<i>Hindu Methods of Tribal Absorption</i> (1941)	Showed Jati influence on tribes of Odisha. Hindu society gradually absorbed tribal groups — some fully integrated into social/economic/political/religious framework, others only partially.
 Martin Orans	<i>The Santhal: A Tribe in Search of a Great Tradition</i> (1965)	Tribes attracted towards Hinduism due to Hindu society influences. Many remain ' tribes ' for namesake only due to Hinduisation.

Mythological Link: Bhils of Central India & Parvati's Curse

- Bhils = traditionally hunter-gatherers and pastoralists
- Myth:** Parvati asked Shiva to gift her brothers (Bhils) something valuable. Shiva gave them his sacred bull **Nandi** (could have been used for ploughing). Greedy brothers killed Nandi hoping to find treasure.

- Parvati's curse:** They and their descendants would never be able to farm.
- Hence Bhils remained outside the farming tradition.
- Significance:** Myth links Bhils to Hindu deities Shiva & Parvati — shows how tribal identity & belief absorbed into broader Hindu framework. Also passes lesson of respect for natural world to younger generations.

Examples of Interaction Between Tribes & Hindu Society

Tribe (Region)	Nature of Interaction
1. Jenu-Kuruba (Karnataka)	Food-gathering tribe skilled in catching & training elephants. Supplied elephants to temples & state armies . Supplied forest products in exchange for goods of necessity. Paid taxes & rents = economic integration with regional systems.
2. Toda (Nilgiris, Tamil Nadu)	Though primarily pastoral, worshipped deity at Nanjangud (Karnataka) , about 140 km away across dense forests = long-distance religious interaction . Those practising settled cultivation developed contacts with neighbouring peasants & caste groups.
3. Munda (Jharkhand, 19th century)	Socially & economically integrated with neighbouring populations. Participated in local markets; shared agricultural practices.

Mythological Narratives as Interaction

Narrative	Summary	Significance
a) Guru Dronacharya & Ekalavya	Ekalavya (tribal boy) denied archery training due to background. Practised alone, became highly skilled. Drona demanded his right thumb as guru-dakshina to maintain Arjuna's supremacy.	Reflects unequal interaction of tribes with caste society
b) Bhima & Hidimbi	After Lakshagriha incident, Pandavas in forest. Bhima encountered Hidimba (tribal woman) who fell in love. Bhima killed brother Hidimb, married Hidimba with Kunti's consent. Son Ghatotkacha played vital role in Mahabharata war.	Shows integration of tribal lineage into epic Hindu tradition

Conclusion: The tribe-caste continuum is a complex and dynamic concept useful for understanding **social mobility and diversity** in Indian society. With increasing Hinduisation and other factors, traditional distinctions are becoming less clear.

ANTHROPOLOGICAL SIGNIFICANCE & CONTEMPORARY RELEVANCE

- **Identity politics:** The continuum explains why communities demand ST status (Gujjars in Rajasthan, Meiteis in Manipur) — they occupy ambiguous positions on the spectrum. UPSC asks about "pseudo-tribalism" in this context.
- **Policy implications:** Is a tribe "backward Hindu" (Ghurye) or a distinct cultural entity (Elwin)? This debate directly determines policy: assimilation vs. protection. The 5th/6th Schedule, FRA 2006, and PESA reflect the protection approach.
- **Census & classification problem:** SC 2024 noted that 'tribe' as a category is colonial — the continuum shows why rigid classification fails. Lokur Committee (1965) criteria themselves acknowledged this ambiguity.
- **Sanskritization & De-Sanskritization:** Tribe-Caste Continuum is the structural backdrop against which Srinivas's Sanskritization operates — tribes moving "rightward" on the continuum often do so through Sanskritization (adopting Hindu rituals, vegetarianism, claiming Kshatriya status).
- **Contemporary application:** Bhil, Gond, Meena communities show varying degrees of integration — useful for anthropological studies of cultural change, acculturation, and resistance.

Inter-linkage: Tribe-Caste Continuum connects to **Jajmani System** (service relationships assimilate tribes into caste hierarchy) and to **Great/Little Tradition** (Hinduisation = absorption of Little Tradition tribal beliefs into Great Tradition framework). Also links to **NMS Complex** (explains why tribes at the "left" end resist movement rightward — their NMS worldview doesn't allow displacement from sacred land).

5.3b GREAT AND LITTLE TRADITION

What is Tradition?

- The word tradition means **'to transmit'**
- Traditions = transmitted values and behaviour of any community that has persisted over time
- Part of culture; observable through: **oral behaviour, social behaviour, material behaviour**

Redfield's Classification

Robert Redfield — *Peasant Society and Culture* (1956): Every society consists of two types of traditions — the tradition of **elite class people** (Great) and the tradition of **non-literate common people** (Little).

Comparison Table

Parameter	Great Tradition	Little Tradition
People	Elite class people	Non-literate peasant/common people
Origin	Emerged from urban centres	Emerged from folk community
Basis	Based on religious texts	Mostly based on traditional beliefs
Transmission	Through formal centres & religious texts	Transmitted orally
Spread	Wide geographical area	More or less localised
Nature	Organised , formal, literate, written	Unorganised , informal, unwritten, oral
Examples	Gita, Ramayana, Upanishads, Bible, Quran (transmitted through formal centres)	Folklore, magical rituals, religious practices not found in religious epics

Another Angle: Great & Little Communities

- Every society has great and little **communities**. Tradition of great community = GT; tradition of little community = LT.
- In Indian context, Hindu community = great community carrying great culture & social structure.

- Within it, many **little communities** in rural and tribal segments carry their own traditions.
- Religious centres like **Gaya, Varanasi** have great traditions — traditional temples where worship & Sanskrit teaching done by **sacred specialists**.
- These sacred specialists try to **popularise myths & legends** to peasants → religious attitudes develop → several rituals come into being.
- **Key point:** Though separate in origin, GT & LT are **interdependent and interact** with each other. Sacred specialists **mediate** between GT & LT, propagating GT elements to LT.

Prominent Example: Jagannath at Puri

Case: Jagannath Puri — GT/LT Integration

- By the 12th century, a **local tribal deity** at Puri (whose image was and continues to be made of **wood by local tribal specialists**) was recognised as **Jagannatha — a form of Vishnu**
- Jagannatha (extreme right), Subhadra (centre, sister), Balarama (left, brother)
- Vishnu was visualized very differently from other parts of India
- **Goddess cults:** Worship of goddess (often a stone smeared with ochre) was widespread. Local deities incorporated within Puranic framework — equated with **Lakshmi** (wife of Vishnu) or **Parvati** (wife of Shiva)

Limitation of GT/LT Framework

Scholars accept the significance but are often uncomfortable with the **hierarchy** suggested by "great" and "little" (hence quotation marks in scholarly writing).

S.C. Dube (1965): Indian cultural realities are "too complex" for a mere '**bipolar model**'. His view is '**multipolar**'. Proposed **sixfold classification**:

#	Tradition Type	Description	Example
1	Classical	Rooted in mythology, Sanskrit texts, religious lore	Ramayana & Mahabharata shaping Hindu culture
2	Regional	Shared cultural traits giving a region its identity, beyond religion	Bhangra (Punjab), Bihu (Assam)
3	Local	Restricted to small groups/areas, often tribal/village-based	Bhuta worship (Karnataka), Karam festival (Jharkhand tribes)
4	Western	Came through colonial contact; shaped ideology & lifestyle	Railways & telegraph (British); Western dress codes among urban elites
5	Emergent national	Linked to revival & national identity formation	Ganesh festival popularised by Bal Gangadhar Tilak during freedom struggle
6	Sub-cultural	Practices of specific elite groups	Mughal court culture (Persian poetry, etiquette); Nawabi traditions of Lucknow (Kathak, <i>tehzeeb</i>); bureaucratic codes of Indian Civil Service under Raj

 **Mandelbaum & S.C. Dube:** The term 'Great Tradition' **can't be a static one** since there's constant interaction & interchange between the two traditions. So it can't be described only in terms of books written hundreds/thousands of years ago.

Conclusion: Redfield's idea of little & great traditions helps understand complex nature of Indian society. GT = formal, dominant culture; LT = local, everyday practices. Their interaction shows how diversity, cultural

mixing, and innovation shape society. Even in globalization age, this framework remains a useful tool for studying culture.

Memory Aid — Dube's 6 Traditions (CRL-WEN-S): Classical | Regional | Local | Western | Emergent National | Sub-cultural


ANTHROPOLOGICAL SIGNIFICANCE & CONTEMPORARY RELEVANCE

- Framework for studying cultural complexity:** GT/LT provides a tool to analyze how elite/classical practices interact with folk/local customs — fundamental to understanding Indian civilization's layered nature.
- Cultural nationalism debates:** RSS/Hindutva's attempt to promote one "Great Tradition" (Vedic/Sanskrit) over diverse Little Traditions parallels the hierarchy problem Dube critiqued. Counter-movements (Dravidian, Bahujan) assert LT as legitimate culture.
- UNESCO Intangible Heritage:** India's ICH nominations (Kumbh Mela, Yoga, Ramlila) show GT elements being institutionalized globally. But many LT practices (Theyyam, tribal dances) remain unrecognized — GT/LT hierarchy persists in cultural policy.
- Digital age transformation:** Social media is creating new channels of transmission — TikTok/Reels spread LT elements (folk songs, tribal dances) to national/global audiences without formal mediation by sacred specialists. This is a new form of Universalisation.
- Anthropological method:** GT/LT framework influenced village studies tradition in India (Srinivas, Dube, Marriott) — any anthropological study of Indian civilization must engage with this framework even if to critique it.

5.3b UNIVERSALISATION & PAROCHIALISATION

Scholar & Background

Aspect	Detail
Scholar	 McKim Marriott
Book	 <i>Village India: Studies in the Little Community</i> (1955)
Background	Marriott & Milton Singer were students of Robert Redfield who came to India and studied village communities. Applied Redfield's concepts in Indian context.
Key insight	GT & LT do not remain as separate compartments but move towards each other

The Two Movements

GREAT TRADITION

↑

UNIVERSALISATION

(LT → GT, upward)

↑

↓

PAROCHIALISATION

(GT → LT, downward)

↓

LITTLE TRADITION

Concept	Direction	Definition
Universalisation	LT → GT (upward)	Local/folk elements get elevated and become part of the pan-Indian Great Tradition
Parochialisation	GT → LT (downward)	Elements of Great Tradition come down and merge into localised Little Tradition

Contextual Introduction: Kerala Example

Andaloor Kavu (near Thalassery, Kannur district)

- People worship **Daivathar, Angakkaran, and Boppooran**
- Theyyam** performances held during festivals — belief is local & transmitted orally = **Little Tradition**
- But these deities are equated with GT deities: **Sreeraman, Lakshmanan, and Hanuman** respectively
- Cannot place this belief in either tradition alone = interplay of Universalisation & Parochialisation

Classic Example: Parochialisation

Gobardhan Puja at Kishangarhi

- GT belief:** Govardhanagiri (hill, ~40 km from Kishangarhi) worshipped as part of Great Tradition — Lord Krishna saved people from furious Indra by lifting Govardhan hill as umbrella
- LT manifestation:** This belief came down to become local tradition. People at Kishangarhi worship **heaps of cow dung** imitating the Govardhan belief
- Gobardhan* = cow dung in Hindi; *Govardhan* = the hill
- Marriott considers this a **parochialised form** of Govardhan puja

Classic Example: Universalisation

Raksha Bandhan from Saluno Festival

- **LT practice at Kishangarhi:** On the day of *Saluno*, married daughters apply **tilak of barley** on foreheads of unmarried sisters & brothers and get money/gifts in return
- Brahmin priests tie Rakhi on their patrons (Jajman) and get something in return
- **GT outcome:** Marriott contends that the festival of **Raksha Bandhan came into being as a result of Universalisation** of festivals like Saluno

Limitation: Circular, Not Two-Directional

Major drawback: U & P as a process is not two-directional but rather **circular and continuous** in operation.

Example: The Ramayana — Circular Process

- **LT:** Oral folk stories told in villages (Little Tradition)
- → **GT:** Shaped into grand Sanskrit epic by **Valmiki** (Great Tradition — pan-Indian classical heritage)
- → **LT:** Translated into regional languages. Tulsidas's **Ramcharitmanas** in Hindi — treasured by ordinary people as household scripture. Recitations in homes & staging of **Ram Lila** dramas in villages = re-enters Little Tradition
- **Cycle:** LT → GT → LT (circular & continuous, not merely two-directional)

Conclusion: Universalisation and Parochialisation highlight the **constant interaction** between GT & LT. Cultural elements move upward into elite traditions and downward into local practices, creating a **circular process of adaptation**. Together, they explain the dynamic and continuous nature of cultural change and integration in Indian society.

ANTHROPOLOGICAL SIGNIFICANCE & CONTEMPORARY RELEVANCE

- **Explains cultural dynamism:** U & P show that Indian culture is not frozen — it's a living, breathing process of constant exchange between elite and folk layers. No tradition is purely "high" or "low."
- **Contemporary Universalisation examples:** Yoga (local ascetic practice → global wellness industry); Ayurveda (village remedies → AYUSH Ministry + WHO recognition); Chhath Puja (Bihar-specific → now national, even diaspora).
- **Contemporary Parochialisation examples:** Valentine's Day → localised as "Propose Day", "Hug Day" in small-town India; Cricket (elite British sport → gully cricket = LT of India).
- **Digital-age acceleration:** Social media accelerates both processes — a local temple ritual goes viral (universalisation) while a Bollywood dance becomes a wedding *sangeet* staple across villages (parochialisation).
- **Policy relevance:** Understanding U & P helps in cultural preservation — when govt. promotes tribal art at national exhibitions, it's a state-driven universalisation that can empower but also commodify.
- **Critique of cultural homogenisation:** Globalisation as mega-universalisation (McDonald's, Netflix) vs. glocalisation as counter-parochialisation (McAloo Tikki, regional OTT content).

Inter-linkage: U & P explains the **mechanism** of Hinduisation in Tribe-Caste Continuum: tribal deities get universalised into Hindu pantheon (Jagannath); Hindu texts get parochialised into local tribal rituals (cow dung as Govardhan). The **Sacred Complex** is the physical site where this exchange happens — sacred specialists are the agents of both U & P.

3.3 SACRED COMPLEX

Concept & Origin

Aspect	Detail
Scholar	L.P. Vidyarthi (1961)
Book	 <i>The Sacred Complex in Hindu Gaya</i>
School	Chicago School of Anthropology
Teacher	 Robert Redfield (also used framework of Redfield & Milton Singer)
Field site	Hindu pilgrim centre Gaya , Magadh, Bihar
Aim	Analyze contribution & importance of traditional centres of Indian civilization in systematic way

Three Components of Sacred Complex

Component	Definition	Example at Gaya
Sacred Geography	Places significant in pilgrim centres where rites are performed; help in cultural transmission of GT elements	Idols in temples, sacred trees, bathing ghats
Sacred Performances	Sets of rites & rituals performed by worshippers; vary with nature & importance of each centre (recitation of mantras, floral offerings, etc.)	Gaya Shraddha (ritual for ancestors)
Sacred Specialists	Maintain distinct style of life; transmit GT to rural population by popularising texts, organising pilgrimage, officiating as ritual/temple priests	Gayawal Brahmins

Sacred Complex = "An intricate and interdependent grouping of sacred geographies, sacred performances, and sacred specialists." It reflects a level of **combination, continuity, & compromise** between elements of GT and LT. — L.P. Vidyarthi

Significance of Sacred Complex (5 Functions)

1. **Cultural transmission:** Unfolds channels which help in **integration of civilisation**
2. **Social integration:** Provides **meeting place** for different kinds of people — castes, sects, classes, statuses
3. **Integrates GT & LT:** Mechanism of sacred complex + institution of pilgrimage = dependable & effective means of integration
4. **Promotes creative arts & literature:** Cultivates varieties of creative arts; helps preserve '**ideal types**' (GT elements)
5. **Binding force:** Binds people together against geographical diversities and social/linguistic heterogeneity

Other Scholars Who Extended the Concept

Scholar (Year)	Study Site	Key Contribution
S.C. Saraswati (1962, 1965)	Naimisharanya (UP), Goa, Kashi (with Jha & Vidyarthi)	Pilgrimage is a sacred act itself — all who participate acquire sacred status. Sacred institutions regulate secular life (festivals, community org., local leadership). Kashi = textual & contextual continuity of sacred geography.
Jha (1971, 1977)	Janakpur (Nepal), Puri	Civilisation transcends political borders — Janakpur in Nepal tied to Indian religious consciousness (Sita's birthplace). Jagannath cult of Puri — origin, rituals, pilgrims' networks. Sacred complexes are dynamic, constantly reinterpreted .
S.C. Bharati (1963, 1970)	Across India	Comprehensive survey across Hindu, Buddhist, Tantric traditions. Inter-religious perspective. Shared yet contested sacred geographies. Growth of new cults alongside older ones.
David Sopher (1968)	Field-based	Service castes (barbers, washermen, priests) crucial to sustaining pilgrim activity. Pilgrimage centres = socio-economic systems where caste roles reinforced.
Bharadwaj (1973)	Multiple	Pilgrim fields, caste composition of pilgrims, hierarchical ranking of sacred places. Sacred complexes = living social institutions , not static religious symbols.
R.N. Narayan (1974)	Deoghar (West Bengal)	Deoghar = microcosm of Indian civilisation . Heterogeneity of pilgrims (caste, class, language, education, political awareness).
Patnaik (1977)	Puri	<i>Cultural Tradition in Puri</i> . Jagannath cult = religious & socio-cultural integrator . Different communities (priests, artisans, service castes, pilgrims) bound by temple traditions.
Narayana Reddy	Tirumala	Applied Vidyarthi's model + added secular dimension : secular geography, secular specialists, secular activities (shops, hotels, employment). Socio-economic background of pilgrims = cross-section of society. Sacred & secular blend = holistic cultural system.

Other visits by Vidyarthi: Apart from Gaya, he undertook short trips to Benaras (Varanasi), Bhubaneshwar, Puri, Deoghar and many rural temples & bathing centres.

Memory Aid — Sacred Complex 3 Components (GPS):
 Geography | Performances | Specialists


ANTHROPOLOGICAL SIGNIFICANCE & CONTEMPORARY RELEVANCE

- Civilizational studies methodology:** Sacred Complex provides a replicable methodological framework for studying any pilgrim centre anthropologically — used at Tirumala, Vaishno Devi, Bodh Gaya, Ajmer Sharif.
- Tourism & economy:** Narayana Reddy's secular dimension is more relevant today than ever — Tirumala's annual revenue (~Rs 3,000+ crore), Kashi Vishwanath Corridor (Rs 800 crore project), Ayodhya Ram Mandir (tourism boom 2024) all show sacred-secular blending.
- Smart Cities & Heritage:** HRIDAY scheme (Heritage City Development) and PRASAD scheme (Pilgrimage Rejuvenation) directly apply Sacred Complex logic — developing sacred geography + supporting sacred specialists + facilitating sacred performances + adding secular infrastructure.
- Social integration in digital age:** Virtual darshan, online pujas, livestreaming of aarti = new forms of sacred performance. Sacred geography expanding into cyberspace.
- Caste & pilgrimage:** David Sopher's insight remains relevant — service castes still essential at Puri, Varanasi, Gaya. Temple entry movements (Dalits at Sabarimala debate) show sacred geography remains contested.
- Trans-national sacred complex:** Jha's Janakpur insight applies to Pashupatinath (Nepal), Bodh Gaya (international Buddhist pilgrimage), Kartarpur Corridor (India-Pakistan) — civilisation transcends political borders.

3.3 NATURE-MAN-SPIRIT (NMS) COMPLEX

Concept & Origin	
Aspect	Detail
Scholar	L.P. Vidyarthi
Basis	Cultural Ecology — constant interaction between Man and Nature
Vidyarthi's addition	Third element — the Spirits
Core principle	Constant interaction between social organization, ecological conditions , and religious complex in the whole of tribal life
Key insight	Arising out of man's close interaction with & dependence on nature is his belief in the supernatural & the spirit world

The Maler Tribe — Vidyarthi's Field Study

Aspect	Detail
Tribe	Maler (hill tribe)
Location	Upper side of Rajmahal Hills
Economy	Shifting cultivation (<i>Khallu</i>)
Social org.	Maintain social organisation on Rajmahal hills

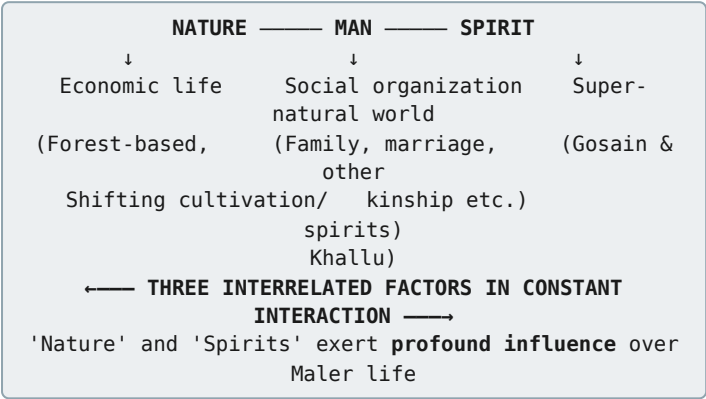
Four Types of Maler Spirits (in framework of sacred geography, performances & specialists)	
Spirit	Nature
Gossaiyan (Gosaiyyan)	Benevolent — governs ALL spirits; bridge between Malers & their concept of superhuman. Malers don't do anything without approval of Gosaiyyan.
Jiwe Urrkya	Ancestral spirits
Alchi	Evil spirits
Chergani	Spiritual power of a witch or witchcraft

Broadly classified into two:

- **Benevolent spirits** — responsible for good health, wealth, and increased agricultural productivity
- **Malevolent spirits** — cause sickness, abortions, ill health, and death

NMS in Action: Maler Displacement

During government developmental activities, Maler tribes were brought down from the hills. Some became ill. Some died. **Malers believed malevolent Gosaïyyan was angry** at them for leaving the hills — displacing them from their sacred geography disturbed their entire NMS equilibrium.



Other Studies Based on NMS Complex

Scholar (Year)	Community	Location	Key Finding
🖋️ Dr. V.S. Sahay (1981)	Nicobarese	A&N Islands	Entirely different setting (forest island surrounded by sea). Same forces operating. All fortunes/misfortunes attributed to benevolent & malevolent spirits hovering around hills, forests & sea. Blood sacrifice of pig & fowl essential. "NMS is the only model which can best describe the essence of Nicobarese Culture."
🖋️ R.K. Prasad (1981)	Parahiya	Bihar	Similar conclusions
🖋️ S.G. Morab	Soliga	Karnataka	Similar conclusions
🖋️ R.S. Mann	Onge	Andamans	Similar conclusions
🖋️ R.K. Sinha	Pando	Madhya Pradesh	Similar conclusions
🖋️ Ramesh Chandra	Kinner	Himachal Pradesh	Similar conclusions
🖋️ Prabhat K. Singh (1986)	Kurmi	Chotanagpur	Similar conclusions

🖋️ **P.K. Singh (1981) — Restudy of Maler:** Studied same villages Vidyarthi did two decades earlier. Concluded: "In spite of many changes in Maler life due to various processes & factors of change, the concept was **valid in time dimension as well.**" After analysing changes & resultant equilibrium, Singh proved: **"The NMS complex cannot change — it is a constant! Even if the content may change through time, the complex itself remains constant."**

Significance of NMS Complex (5 Points with Examples)

#	Significance	Example
1	Holistic worldview — highlights unity of nature, man & spirit; humans as part of ecological & spiritual order	Santhals: Baha festival involves worship of village deities along with sacred groves (Jaherthan), linking ecology, community, & spirit
2	Explains resistance to change — why tribes resist relocation, mining, large-scale dams (disruption of sacred land disturbs entire worldview)	Dongria Kondh of Odisha resisted Vedanta's bauxite mining in Niyamgiri Hills , calling mountain ' Niyam Raja '. Opposition rooted in NMS beliefs, not just material livelihood.
3	Tool for applied anthropology — guides culturally sensitive development	Verrier Elwin's "Tribal Panchsheel" (1950s) stressed minimal interference & respecting tribal culture — recognising NMS worldview in development policy
4	Sustainable use of resources — sacred taboos & rituals maintain ecological balance	Khasi & Garo tribes of Meghalaya conserve sacred groves — cutting trees or removing leaves is prohibited
5	Integration of tradition & development — development must include spiritual & cultural dimensions	In Jharkhand & Chhattisgarh, tribal communities combine traditional Sarhul festival (worship of sal trees & earth goddess) with community discussions about agriculture & water use

📁 **CASE STUDY: Dongria Kondh & Niyamgiri Hills**

- **Who:** 15,000+ Kondh tribes (Dongria & Kutia) living in **160 villages** across Rayagada & Kalahandi districts, Odisha
- **Sacred belief:** Tribes consider hills sacred; worship it as '**Niyam Raja**'
- **Peaceful life:** Till early 2000s, lived peacefully in inaccessible hamlets on slopes of Niyamgiri range
- **Threat (2004):** Vedanta set up pit-head alumina refinery at **Lanjigarh** (foothills of Niyamgiri)
- **Stakes:** Odisha has **700 million tonnes** known bauxite reserves; **88 million tonnes** estimated in Niyamgiri
- **Violations:** Stringent environmental laws violated; Dongria's consent not sought
- **SC Ruling (April 18, 2013):** Supreme Court directed that mining clearance can only be given if **gram sabhas comprising Dongrias agreed** to the project
- **Result:** All **12 villages** selected by government **voted AGAINST** the project = **India's first environmental referendum**

Conclusion: The NMS complex shows that development must consider spiritual & cultural dimensions along with economic & technological ones. It stresses **harmony between humans, nature, and the spirit world**, making development more holistic & sustainable. This concept is both **theoretically important for Development Anthropology** and **practically relevant for tribal development planners**, whose aim should be to ensure welfare schemes bring not just progress but also happiness.

ANTHROPOLOGICAL SIGNIFICANCE & CONTEMPORARY RELEVANCE

- **Development Anthropology:** NMS is the foundational concept justifying anthropological input in development planning. Without understanding NMS, projects like Sardar Sarovar (Narmada), Polavaram, and POSCO fail to account for tribal worldviews — leading to resistance, displacement trauma, and project delays.
- **FPIC (Free Prior Informed Consent):** The Niyamgiri verdict (2013) established the legal principle that tribal consent must precede development — this is the legal institutionalisation of NMS respect. Now cited globally as best practice.
- **Climate change & TEK:** NMS explains why tribal ecological knowledge (TEK) is valuable — tribes who live in NMS harmony with nature have sustainable practices (sacred groves, rotational farming, fire management). IPCC now recognises indigenous knowledge as climate adaptation tool.
- **Sacred groves as carbon sinks:** SC's 2024 Orans judgment (Rajasthan sacred groves = forests) directly validates NMS worldview in environmental law. India has 14,000+ sacred groves = community-conserved biodiversity hotspots.
- **Mental health & displacement:** NMS explains displacement trauma — when tribes are relocated (dams, mining), they lose not just land but their **spiritual universe**. High rates of alcoholism, depression, suicide among displaced Adivasis linked to NMS disruption.
- **PM-JANMAN (2023-24):** Rs 24,000 crore scheme for 75 PVTGs acknowledges culturally sensitive approach — echoes Elwin's Tribal Panchsheel which was itself informed by NMS understanding.

 **Inter-linkage:** NMS Complex is the **tribal equivalent** of Sacred Complex — both show how spirit/religion governs daily life. While Sacred Complex works at **pilgrim centres** (civilizational level), NMS works at **tribal habitat level**. Both studied by Vidyarthi. NMS explains why tribes at the "isolated" end of Tribe-Caste Continuum **resist movement** toward caste society — displacement from sacred geography = existential threat to their worldview.

CURRENT HOOKS (Recent Developments for Mains Answers)

#	Development (Year)	Topic Link	Use in Answer
1	SC Judgment on Orans (2024): Supreme Court declared Rajasthan's sacred groves (<i>Orans</i>) as 'forests', directing Centre to draft national policy for managing sacred groves	NMS Complex / Sacred Groves	Validates NMS worldview in environmental jurisprudence; shows traditional conservation has legal recognition
2	PM-JANMAN (2023-24): Rs 24,000 crore for 75 PVTGs across 18 states — housing, roads, health, education, livelihood with culturally sensitive approach	Tribe-Caste Continuum / NMS	Modern state acknowledging need for Elwin's Panchsheel approach; development must respect tribal worldview
3	Sacred Groves Research (2026): Wiley journal study on community values & management of sacred groves in Mayurbhanj, Odisha	NMS Complex	Academic validation that NMS traditions persist; community-based conservation works
4	Democratization & Jajmani (2025): Research documenting how democratization & electoral mobilization has fundamentally transformed Jajmani relations	Jajmani System decline	Political mobilization thesis (3rd cause of decline) confirmed by contemporary research
5	Niyamgiri as Global Precedent (ongoing): 2013 SC verdict continues to be cited as landmark for FPIC in development projects	NMS / Tribal rights	India's contribution to global indigenous rights jurisprudence; gram sabha as democratic expression of NMS beliefs

QUICK REVISION CHEAT SHEET

Topic	Main Points (Keywords)	Key Scholars	Examples	Key Case Studies	Anthropological Relevance
Jajmani System	Agriculture-based production/distribution; 6 features: Permanent, Hereditary, Goods-vs-services, Social, Peace, Ritual; Self-sufficient village; Decline: STP (State + Tech + Political)	W.H. Wiser (1936, Karimpur); Oscar Lewis (1958, Rampur); N.S. Reddy (hereditary); Pauline Kolenda (1963, distribution); Berreman (1953, dynamics); Harold Gould (1972, family-level); Yogendra Singh (4 change factors)	10 castes serving Thakur family; Safety razors/steel utensils/bore wells replacing artisans; Yajamani (TN), Jenmi (Kerala)	Rampur village exploitation; Thakur family 10-caste ritual	Pre-capitalist labour relations; Caste-class nexus; Functionalism vs conflict debate; MGNREGA as modern parallel
Tribe-Caste Continuum	Gradual progression; No sharp boundaries; Folk-Urban model applied; 4 classifications; Hinduisation; Tribal absorption	R. Redfield (continuum); J.H. Hutton (religious); Andre Beteille (3 criteria); F.G. Bailey (structural); Surajit Sinha (Bastar); Ghurye (backward Hindus); N.K. Bose (absorption, 1941); Martin Orans (Santhal, 1965)	Spectrum: Onge → Chenchu → Gonds → Bhumi; Bhils in Ramayana; Jenu-Kuruba (elephants); Toda (Nanjangud)	Ekalavya-Drona (unequal interaction); Bhima-Hidimbi (integration); Parvati's curse (Bhils)	Identity politics (ST demand); Sanskritization process; Census classification problem; Policy: assimilation vs protection
Great & Little Tradition	GT = elite/formal/literate/urban/written; LT = folk/oral/local/unorganised; Interdependent; Sacred specialists mediate; Bipolar vs Multipolar	Robert Redfield (1956, Peasant Society & Culture); S.C. Dube (1965, multipolar, 6-fold); Mandelbaum (GT not static)	GT: Gita, Ramayana, Gaya, Varanasi; LT: Folklore, local rituals; Jagannath Puri (tribal → Vishnu); Goddess cults (stone → Lakshmi/Parvati)	Jagannath Puri; Dube's 6 traditions (CRL-WEN-S)	Cultural nationalism debate; UNESCO ICH; Digital transmission; Village studies tradition
Universalisation & Parochialisation	U = LT → GT (upward); P = GT → LT (downward); Not linear but CIRCULAR; Continuous; Field: Kishangarhi	McKim Marriott (1955, Village India); Milton Singer; Robert Redfield (teacher)	P: Gobardhan Puja (cow dung = Govardhan hill); U: Saluno → Raksha Bandhan; Kerala: Theyyam = Rama/Lakshman/Hanuman	Ramayana cycle: folk → Valmiki → Tulsidas → Ram Lila	Yoga/Ayurveda universalisation; Digital-age acceleration; Glocalisation; Cultural preservation policy
Sacred Complex	3 components: GPS (Geography + Performances + Specialists); Combination/continuity/compromise of GT & LT; Social integration; Cultural transmission; 8 extending scholars	L.P. Vidyarthi (1961, Hindu Gaya, Chicago School); Saraswati; Jha (Janakpur, Puri); Bharati; David Sopher; Bharadwaj; R.N. Narayan (Deoghar); Patnaik (Puri); Narayana Reddy (Tirumala + secular)	Gaya: Gayawal Brahmins + Shraddha + ghats; Tirumala: sacred+secular; Janakpur: trans-national	Narayana Reddy's secular dimension; Jha's trans-border civilisation	PRASAD/HRIDAY schemes; Tourism economy; Virtual darshan; Temple entry movements; Kartarpur Corridor
NMS Complex	Nature + Man + Spirit in constant interaction; Cultural Ecology + Spirits; Complex is CONSTANT (P.K. Singh); Tribal worldview; 5 significances	L.P. Vidyarthi (Maler, Rajmahal); V.S. Sahay (1981, Nicobarese - "only model"); P.K. Singh (1981, "constant!"); R.K. Prasad; S.G. Morab; R.S. Mann; R.K. Sinha; Ramesh Chandra; Prabhat K. Singh; Verrier Elwin (Panchsheel)	4 Maler spirits (Gossaiyan/Jiwe Urrkya/Alchi/Chergani); Khallu; Baha+Jaherthan (Santhals); Khasi/Garo groves; Sarhul festival	Dongria Kondh vs Vedanta (Niyamgiri) : 88M tonnes bauxite; SC 2013; 12 gram sabhas voted NO = 1st env. referendum	FPIC principle; TEK & climate; SC Orans 2024; PM-JANMAN; Displacement trauma; Development Anthropology

Key Definitions (One-Liners for Answer Writing)

Term	Definition	Scholar
Jajmani System	"Each caste group within a village gives certain standardized services to families of other castes"	Oscar Lewis (1958), based on Wiser
Great Tradition	Tradition of elite class, transmitted through formal centres (schools, religious institutions, books) in formal, literate manner	Robert Redfield (1956)
Little Tradition	Tradition of non-literate common people, transmitted orally from one generation to another	Robert Redfield (1956)
Universalisation	Upward movement of elements of Little Tradition to become part of Great Tradition	McKim Marriott (1955)
Parochialisation	Downward movement of elements of Great Tradition to merge into Little Tradition	McKim Marriott (1955)
Sacred Complex	"An intricate and interdependent grouping of sacred geographies, sacred performances, and sacred specialists"	L.P. Vidyarthi (1961)
NMS Complex	Constant interaction between social organization (man), ecological conditions (nature), and religious complex (spirit) in tribal life	L.P. Vidyarthi
Folk-Urban Continuum	Cultural shift from rural to urban is a gradual process, not sudden	R. Redfield
Tribe-Caste Continuum	Gradual range from totally isolated tribal groups to totally assimilated caste groups; process of social mobility	Bailey & Surajit Sinha

Answer Writing Building Blocks

If asked about...	Must include
Jajmani System	Lewis definition + Wiser (1936) + 6 features + Ritual example + STP decline + Contemporary remnants (ritual Jajmani persists)
Tribe-Caste Continuum	Redfield's Folk-Urban → Bailey/Sinha applied to India + Spectrum diagram + 4 scholars + Ghurye vs Elwin + Bose/Orans on Hinduisation + Example (Jenu-Kuruba/Toda/Munda)
Great/Little Tradition	Redfield (1956) + Comparison table + Sacred specialists as mediators + Jagannath Puri + Dube's critique (6-fold) + Mandelbaum (not static)
Universalisation & Parochialisation	Marriott (1955) + Diagram + P: Gobardhan + U: Saluno → Rakhi + Limitation: circular (Ramayana cycle) + Contemporary examples
Sacred Complex	Vidyarthi (1961, Gaya, Chicago School) + GPS components + 5 significances + At least 3 extending scholars + Narayana Reddy secular dimension
NMS Complex	Vidyarthi + Maler (Rajmahal, Khallu, 4 spirits) + P.K. Singh ("constant!") + Sahay (Nicobarese) + 5 significances + Dongria Kondh case + Elwin Panchsheel